



Flawed approach: India's persistence with Nitish Reddy is symptomatic of Gambhir's obsession with all-rounders, an idea he has carried over from white-ball cricket. PTI

undercut itself by destabilising its batting order. After projecting B. Sai Sudharsan as its future No. 3, the Indian management dropped him for the first Test and promoted Washington Sundar to that role.

Washington, to his credit, was the most stable-looking Indian batter in Kolkata. He faced more deliveries than any other batter on the minefield that was the Eden Gardens pitch. Gill's injury then forced a reshuffle in Guwahati — Sai Sudharsan returned to his No. 3 position, while Washington was 'rewarded' for his assured batting with a demotion to No. 8.

India's batting line-up was also weakened by an over-representation of southpaws. It was an issue the team failed to identify until Harmer exposed it in Kolkata.

Even after Gill succumbed to injury, the home team did not add a specialist right-handed batter and instead went into the second Test with all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy.

India's persistence with Nitish is



symptomatic of Gambhir's obsession with all-rounders, an idea he has carried over from white-ball cricket.

There is no denying that great all-rounders are an incredibly valuable asset to any team, in any format. But Gambhir appears to have overestimated their value in Test cricket, where specialised abilities still retain merit.

The Nitish conundrum is a fine example. Despite earmarking the 22-year-old as a pace-bowling option, the team was hesitant to hand him the ball. India bowled a whopping 229.4 overs in Guwahati, with Nitish delivering just 10 of them. In fact, in the second innings, part-time leggie Yashasvi Jaiswal (**below**) bowled an over before him. Nitish struggled to make an impact with the bat as well. Jansen bounced him out in the first innings and he was caught behind off Harmer in the second.

If India desires to mould Nitish into a genuine pace all-rounder, force-fitting him into the Test side for the sake of experience and then underusing him is certainly not the way to do it.

This brings us back to the selection question — would India have been better served by a specialist batter in Guwahati? Say, a Karun Nair, Sarfaraz Khan, or even a Ruturaj Gaikwad?

It was only natural that India's undercooked pre-game planning spilt onto the field. In Kolkata, despite having watched South African skipper Temba Bavuma bat his way out of trouble, the Indian batters, except for Washington, struggled to apply themselves, eventually strangling their chase of 124.

In Guwahati, India allowed the game to slip away in the morning session of Day 2. Having reduced South Africa to 246 for six on Day 1, many would have expected India to swoop in for the kill.

But stand-in skipper Rishabh Pant afforded Senuran Muthusamy and Kyle Verreynne breathing room with overtly defensive field set-ups. South Africa batted through the session before Jansen launched the innings out of orbit with a furious assault.

Having seen the merits of playing out the tricky morning